

DREAMING AGES HISTORY · EPISODE 7

Byzantium

A Calm Journey Through Constantinople

✦ ✦ ✦

A BEDTIME COMPANION

Two maps, a timeline from 330 to 1453, the people and places you'll meet in the episode, and a short list of trusted books, museums and podcasts, for the evenings when you would like to wander a little further.

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Constantinople, between two shores

Let's begin in the city on the water.



Surviving Byzantine sites plotted at their real locations on today's Istanbul. The coastline is modern; parts of the shore have since been filled in. The gold line marks the surviving Theodosian land walls.

AT A GLANCE

- The city stood on a hilly headland at the southern end of the Bosphorus
- The sheltered Golden Horn lay to the north
- The Sea of Marmara lay to the south
- Theodosius II's great land walls closed the west

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Places you'll visit in the episode

Ten places from the episode, from Hagia Sophia to the Galata Tower.

Hagia Sophia · The church of Holy Wisdom, dedicated in December 537, under a dome more than 30 m across.

Basilica Cistern · Justinian's underground hall of more than 300 columns, where water rested for dry months.

Hippodrome · The long racing ground beside the palace, home of the Blues and the Greens.

Great Palace · A maze of halls, gardens and terraces running down from the Hippodrome to the sea.

The Mese · The "middle street", lined with colonnades, running west through the great forums.

Column of Constantine · Purple porphyry in Constantine's forum, still standing, bound with iron rings.

Valens Aqueduct · A surviving bridge of the water system that brought water from the hills of Thrace.

Theodosian Walls · A moat, an outer wall and a tall inner wall, about six kilometres from sea to Horn.

Chora · A small church restored by Theodore Metochites in the early 1300s, filled with mosaics and frescoes.

Galata Tower · The tall stone tower of the Genoese walled town across the Golden Horn.

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ELEVEN CENTURIES, SLOWLY

A timeline, 330 to 1453

Eleven centuries of New Rome, one quiet step at a time.

AT A GLANCE

11 May 330
Nova Roma

December 537
Hagia Sophia

April 1204
The Fourth Crusade

29 May 1453
The fall

Long before, in about 660 BCE by ancient tradition, Greek settlers said to be from Megara founded a town called Byzantion on this headland.

324 — Constantine the Great wins a decisive battle nearby, on the Asian shore, and chooses old Byzantion for a new capital.

11 May 330 — The city is formally dedicated: *Nova Roma*, New Rome, soon called Constantinople.

Early 400s — The great land walls are raised under Theodosius II.

476 — The last emperor in the west is set aside. In the east, the empire carries on.

527 — Justinian becomes emperor, with the empress Theodora beside him.

January 532 — The Nika riot. Fires spread and the old Hagia Sophia burns.

December 537 — The new Hagia Sophia is dedicated, finished in less than six years.

541–542 — Plague arrives from Egypt and reaches Constantinople in 542.

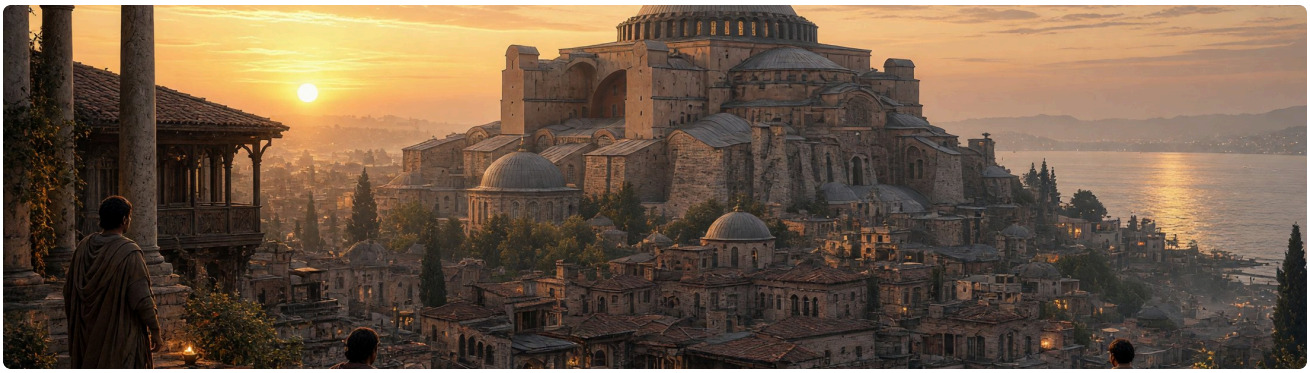
630s–640s — New Arab armies take Syria, Palestine and then Egypt.

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ELEVEN CENTURIES, SLOWLY

A timeline, 330 to 1453

The story goes on from here, slowly.



c. 670s	“Liquid fire”, later called Greek fire, appears; its recipe is still unknown.
717–718	A great siege fails; the walls hold through a bitter winter.
754 · 787 · 843	Iconoclasm: a council condemns holy images (754); Nicaea restores them (787); they are restored for good (843).
9th century	Cyril and Methodius of Thessalonica create a Slavic alphabet; Cyrillic grows from their work.
976–1025	Basil II rules, longer than any other Byzantine emperor.
c. 988	Vladimir of Kyiv sends warriors and accepts Christianity; the Varangian Guard grows from them.
1054	The date often given for the schism with Rome, though the parting was slow.
1071	Defeat at Manzikert; Romanos IV is captured, then released.
1081 · 1096–97	Alexios I Komnenos takes the throne; First Crusade armies arrive at the city.

ELEVEN CENTURIES, SLOWLY

A timeline, 330 to 1453

April 1204	The Fourth Crusade sacks Constantinople; a Latin empire rules for nearly sixty years.
1261	The city is recovered; Michael VIII Palaiologos enters on foot.
Early 1300s	Theodore Metochites restores the Chora church with mosaics and frescoes.
1439	At the Council of Florence the churches agree a union, bitterly opposed at home.
29 May 1453	The city falls to Sultan Mehmed II, who makes it his capital.

An empire that rose and shrank

Now let's step back and watch the empire rise and shrink.



Approximate extent around 600 CE (after Justinian's reconquests in North Africa, Italy and southern Spain) and around 1000 CE, in the reign of Basil II. Frontiers moved often; borders are simplified. By Basil's death in 1025 the empire also took in the Bulgarian lands up to the Danube.

People you'll meet

The emperors, scholars and builders you'll meet along the way.

Constantine the Great · Chose old Byzantion as his new capital and dedicated it in 330.

Justinian I · Emperor 527–565; laws, the new Hagia Sophia, and long wars in the west.

Theodora · Empress, clever and strong-willed, a real partner in power; died in 548.

Procopius · Justinian's historian, and author of the bitter *Secret History*.

Anthemius & Isidore · The two designers, learned in geometry, behind Hagia Sophia.

Photios · Patriarch and scholar whose notes are the only trace of some lost books.

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People you'll meet

Cyril & Methodius · Brothers from Thessalonica who devised an alphabet for the Slavs.

Basil II · Reigned nearly fifty years and conquered the Bulgarian empire; died 1025.

Anna Komnene · Learned princess who wrote the *Alexiad* about her father, Alexios I.

Theodore Metochites · Scholar and statesman who restored the Chora in the early 1300s.

Constantine XI Palaiologos · The last emperor, who died in the fighting in 1453.

Mehmed II · The young Ottoman sultan who took the city and made it his capital.

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WHILE YOU LISTEN

Things to spot, legend and history

A few things to listen for, and a note on legend and history.

THINGS TO SPOT IN THE EPISODE

- The dome of Hagia Sophia, more than 30 m across
- The more than 300 columns of the Basilica Cistern
- The Blues and the Greens at the Hippodrome
- “Liquid fire”, whose recipe is still unknown
- Michael VIII Palaiologos entering the city on foot in 1261

LEGEND OR HISTORY?

Some of Byzantium’s most famous stories rest on a single writer or on much later legend: Theodora’s “royalty is a good burial shroud” (told only by Procopius), Justinian’s boast that he had surpassed Solomon (written down long afterwards), Basil II’s thousands of blinded prisoners (numbers probably exaggerated), and the marble emperor sleeping beneath the Golden Gate (Greek folk legend after 1453). The episode keeps these clearly apart from what the sources and the surviving buildings show.

FOR ANOTHER QUIET EVENING

Books to read

If you'd like to wander a little further, here are some trusted places to start.

Byzantium: The Surprising Life of a Medieval Empire ↗, Judith Herrin (2007; Princeton University Press).

The New Roman Empire: A History of Byzantium ↗, Anthony Kaldellis (Oxford University Press, 2023).

The Byzantines ↗, Averil Cameron (Blackwell, 2006).

Lost to the West: The Forgotten Byzantine Empire That Rescued Western Civilization ↗, Lars Brownworth (Crown, 2009).

The Fall of Constantinople 1453 ↗, Steven Runciman (Cambridge University Press, 1965).

The Alexiad ↗, Anna Komnene, trans. E. R. A. Sewter, revised by Peter Frankopan (Penguin Classics, 2009).

📚 FIND THESE BOOKS — TAP HERE →

Full reading list ↗

Museums and places

Museums & places

Royal Ontario Museum, Toronto: the Joey and Toby Tanenbaum Gallery of Byzantium.

Byzantine and Christian Museum, Athens.

Dumbarton Oaks Museum, Washington, DC: the Byzantine Collection.

In Istanbul: Hagia Sophia, the Basilica Cistern and the Chora (Kariye), now a mosque, open to visitors outside prayer times.





Artistic impressions of the Basilica Cistern and of fishermen rowing home at dawn, made for the episode. They are not historical records.

FOR ANOTHER QUIET EVENING

Podcasts, and one last thought

Podcasts

The History of Byzantium, Robin Pierson: the empire from 476 to 1453, now complete.

12 Byzantine Rulers, Lars Brownworth: a short classic series of lectures.

A BEDTIME QUESTION

If you could stand in one place in Constantinople tonight, would it be beneath the dome of Hagia Sophia, or beside the still water of the Basilica Cistern?

"The Basilica Cistern at night, its columns standing in still water, a single drop falling and spreading in slow rings."

LISTEN TO THE FULL EPISODE, AND FIND THE NEXT ONE

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